

Body Soul Constitution

doc-body-soul-constitution

Anthropology · Constitution of Man · doctrine · divided_lineages · brethren distinctive

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Human beings are a unity of material body and immaterial soul/spirit; whether constitution is dichotomous (body+soul) or trichotomous (body+soul+spirit) is a debated but in-house question.

In plain language

The Bible steadily portrays a human person as a unity of a material body and an immaterial life. In Genesis 2:7 the LORD forms the man from the dust of the ground and breathes the breath of life into his nostrils, and the man becomes a living being (in Hebrew, nephesh chayyah, a whole living self). Two ingredients combine and the result is one living person. Jesus in Matthew 10:28 separates those who can kill the body (soma) from the one who can destroy both soul (psyche) and body, which assumes the soul outlasts the killing of the body. Paul in 2 Corinthians 5:8 speaks of being away from the body and at home with the Lord, again a self that continues when the body is left. Ecclesiastes 12:7 states the death pattern: the dust returns to the earth and the spirit (ruach) returns to God who gave it. Two parts, plainly. Whether the immaterial side is one principle or two is much harder to settle from the words alone, and that is where readers diverge. The two key Greek words, soul (psyche) and spirit (pneuma), appear together in only five verses of the whole New Testament, and only First Thessalonians 5:23 (spirit, soul, and body) and Hebrews 4:12 (the word dividing soul and spirit) set them side by side at all. In First Thessalonians the three words sit under one singular adjective and one singular verb, so the line reads just as well as a prayer for the whole person as a list of three parts. In Hebrews soul and spirit stand in the same grammar as joints and marrow, so the sentence may mean the word divides soul from spirit, or simply that it pierces the deepest interior. Meanwhile the Hebrew words for breath (neshamah), spirit (ruach), and soul or self (nephesh) trade places freely, as when the soul (nephesh) departs at death in Genesis 35:18 but the spirit (ruach) departs in Ecclesiastes 12:7. So the vocabulary firmly supports the body and immaterial-life unity, but it does not rank the two-part and three-part readings of the inner side, which is why that question stays open and in-house.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0120	אָדָם	'adam	man	552
H1320	בָּשָׂר	basar	flesh	270
H2416	חַי	chay	alive	
H3820	לֵב	leb	heart	595
H5315	נֶפֶשׁ	nephesh	soul	754
H5397	נִשְׁמָה	neshamah	breath	24
H6083	עָפָר	'aphar	dust	110
H7307	רוּחַ	ruach	spirit	378

G0037	ἀγιάζω	hagiazō	to sanctify	
G0615	ἀποκτείνω	apokteinō	to kill	
G0622	ἀπόλλυμι	apolluō	to destroy	
G0719	ἄρμος	harmos	joint	
G1067	γέεννα	geenna	hell	
G1553	ἐκδημέω	ekdemeo	be away	3
G1736	ἐνδημέω	endemeo	be home	3
G2588	καρδιά	kardia	heart	156
G2962	κύριος	kurios	lord	
G3311	μερισμός	merismos	division	2
G3452	μυελός	muelos	marrow	
G3648	ὅλοκληρος	holoklēros	whole	
G4151	πνεῦμα	pneuma	spirit/breath	379
G4152	πνευματικός	pneumatikos	spiritual	26
G4561	σὰρξ	sarx	flesh	147
G4983	σῶμα	soma	body	144
G5590	ψυχή	psyche	soul	102
G5591	ψυχικός	psychikos	natural	6

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The lexical pattern across both Testaments presents the human person as a composite of a material constituent (the physical body side) and an immaterial constituent (the inner life side), and this primary claim is decisive. Genesis 2:7 joins dust (‘aphar, 110 occurrences) with breath (neshamah, 24 occurrences) and the product is a living being (nephesh chayyah); the term self or life (nephesh) recurs 754 times for the whole living self. Matthew 10:28 sets body (soma) against soul (psyche) as targets of different harm, and 2 Corinthians 5:8 assumes a self that is at home or away from the body (soma). Ecclesiastes 12:7 names the death-split: dust (‘aphar) to earth, spirit (ruach) to God. The second-tier sub-claim, whether the immaterial side is one principle (dichotomy, a two-part view of the person) or two (trichotomy, a three-part view of the person), is lexically underdetermined (not settled by the words alone). Soul (psyche, 102 New Testament occurrences) and spirit (pneuma, 379) co-occur in only five New Testament verses, and only 1 Thessalonians 5:23 and Hebrews 4:12 set them in any partition; in both the grammar reads as well as a whole-person merism (a two-part figure naming the extremes to mean the whole) as an ontological enumeration (a list of distinct substances), and the Old Testament terms spirit (ruach), breath (neshamah), and soul or self (nephesh) interchange freely for the inner life. The proposition itself labels that partition debated and in-house, so the verdict affirms the unity it asserts.

Scripture

Gen.2.7 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H6083 עפר, H5397 נְשָׁמָה, H5315 שָׁפָץ, H0120 אָדָם

Reasoning. Yahweh forms the man (‘adam) from the dust (‘aphar) of the ground and breathes the breath of life (nishmat chayyim) into his nostrils, and the man becomes a living being (nephesh chayyah). The Hebrew of this verse, confirmed in the OSHB (Open Scriptures Hebrew Bible) word layer, contains dust (‘aphar), breath (neshamah), soul or self (nephesh), and man (‘adam) but NOT spirit (ruach); the material dust and the divine breath combine and the composite product is one living person. Soul or self (nephesh) here denotes the whole animate creature, not a detachable inner part, so the verse grounds the material-plus-immaterial unity without by itself establishing any partition within the immaterial side.

Matt.10.28 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G4983 σῶμα, G5590 ψυχή, G0615 ἀποκτείνω, G0622 ἀπόλλυμι, G1067 γέννω

Reasoning. Jesus distinguishes those who can kill the body (soma, in the accusative singular form, the grammatical case marking a direct object) but cannot kill the soul (psyche, also accusative singular) from the one who can destroy both soul (psyche) and body (soma) in hell (gehenna). The MorphGNT (a morphologically tagged Greek New Testament) parsing shows body (soma) and soul (psyche) as two distinct accusative objects of two contrasted verbs, with the soul surviving the killing of the body. This is a clean binary contrast of a material and an immaterial constituent and is the strongest single witness for the primary unity claim.

2Cor.5.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1553 ἐκδημέω, G1736 ἐνδημέω, G4983 σῶμα, G2962 κύριος

Reasoning. Paul prefers to be away from (ekdemesai ek) the body (tou somatos) and at home with (endemesai pros) the Lord (ton kyrion). The grammatical form of the body (tou somatos) is a genitive (a noun in the 'of-X' or 'from-X' grammatical case), naming the thing departed from, and the continuing personal subject (the we who are confident and prefer) is grammatically distinct from the body (soma). This supports a two-part constitution: a material body and an immaterial self capable of conscious presence with the Lord apart from the body. It says nothing about a third constituent.

Eccl.12.7 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H6083 עפר, H7307 רֶחַץ

Reasoning. The dust (‘aphar) returns to the earth as it was and the spirit (ruach) returns to God who gave it. The OSHB (Open Scriptures Hebrew Bible) word layer confirms dust (‘aphar) and spirit (ruach) in this verse. This is a clear binary separation at death: the material constituent to the ground, the immaterial constituent to God. The death pattern names two elements, not three, and so coheres with the dichotomy (two-part) reading of the immaterial side while still grounding the basic material-immaterial unity.

1Thess.5.23 · for · genre: epistle · figures: merism

Key terms. G4151 πνεῦμα, G5590 ψυχή, G4983 σῶμα, G0037 ἀγιάζω, G3648 ὁλόκληρος

Reasoning. Paul prays that the God of peace would sanctify the addressees completely (holoteleis, wholly) and that their spirit (pneuma) and soul (psyche) and body (soma) be preserved blamelessly. MorphGNT (a morphologically tagged Greek New Testament) confirms three nominative-singular nouns (subjects in the singular) in series joined by repeated and (kai), governed by a single adjective whole or complete (holokleron) and a third-singular optative verb (a singular wish-or-prayer verb form) be kept (teretheie). The singular adjective and singular verb governing the triple subject are the lexical hook that lets the line be read as an exhaustive whole-person prayer (a merism, a two-part or multi-part figure naming the extremes to mean the whole) just as readily as a list of three ontological parts (distinct substances of the self). The grammar does not rank the two readings.

Heb.4.12 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5590 ψυχή, G4151 πνεῦμα, G3311 μερισμός, G0719 ἄρμός, G3452 μυελός

Reasoning. The word (logos) of God pierces as far as the dividing (achri merismou, where merismos means a division or separation) of soul (psyche) and spirit (pneumatōs), of joints (harmon) and marrow (myelon). MorphGNT (a morphologically tagged Greek New Testament) shows division (merismou) in the genitive case (the 'of-X' form), governing soul (psyche) and spirit (pneuma, both genitive singular) in parallel with joints (harmon) and marrow (myelon, genitive plural). Because the soul-spirit pair stands in the same construction as the physical joints-and-marrow pair, the genitives are genuinely ambiguous: they can be partitive (a 'separating' use, the word divides soul from spirit) or objective (the word penetrates through the whole interior, soul and spirit alike). The verse asserts the penetrating discernment of the word, and the construction by itself does not settle whether soul (psyche) and spirit (pneuma) are separable constituents.

Gen.35.18 · neutral · genre: narrative

Key terms. H5315 נִשְׁמָה

Reasoning. As her soul or self (nephesh) was departing, for she was dying, Rachel named her son. The OSHB (Open Scriptures Hebrew Bible) word layer confirms soul or self (nephesh) in this verse alongside the dying-and-departing language. Here soul or self (nephesh) is the life or self that leaves the body at death, the same immaterial referent that elsewhere is carried by spirit (ruach, Ecclesiastes 12:7). This in-canon interchange of soul or self (nephesh) and spirit (ruach) for the departing inner person is exactly why the words do not cleanly rank a two-part versus three-part immaterial constitution.

Gen.7.22 · neutral · genre: narrative

Key terms. H5397 נִשְׁמַת, H7307 רוּחַ

Reasoning. All in whose nostrils was the breath of the spirit of life (nishmat-ruach chayyim) died in the flood. The OSHB (Open Scriptures Hebrew Bible) word layer confirms both breath (neshamah) and spirit (ruach) in this verse, standing together in a tight grammatical construct (a chained noun phrase) as the breath-of-spirit-of-life. The two terms here function as overlapping near-synonyms for the one life-breath rather than as two discrete substances, which complicates any clean lexical separation of the immaterial into ranked parts.

Job.27.3 · neutral · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H5397 נִשְׁמַת, H7307 רוּחַ

Reasoning. As long as my breath (neshamah) is in me and the spirit (ruach) of God (Eloah) is in my nostrils, Job swears. The OSHB (Open Scriptures Hebrew Bible) word layer confirms breath (neshamah) and spirit (ruach) in this verse, set in a tight poetic couplet (a two-line pairing) where both denote the divinely given life-breath within the speaker. The two Hebrew terms function as near-synonyms in this line, reinforcing that lexical labels alone cannot fix how many immaterial constituents the person has.

1Cor.2.14 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5591 ψυχικός, G4152 πνευματικός

Reasoning. Paul contrasts the natural person (psychikos anthropos, where natural or soulish (psychikos) occurs 6 times in the New Testament) with the spiritual person (pneumatikos, 26 times) regarding receptivity to the things of the Spirit of God. The adjectival contrast describes two modes of human existence relative to God rather than two substances inside one human, so it does not by itself establish a trichotomous ontology (a three-substance view of the person); here spirit (pneuma) language points to the Holy Spirit and to the person under the Spirit, not to a third part of the self.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Gen.2.7	Gen.3.19	tsk	1

Gen.2.7	Gen.7.22	tsk	1
Gen.2.7	Job.27.3	tsk	1
Gen.2.7	Num.16.22	tsk	1
Gen.2.7	Ps.100.3	tsk	1
1Thess.5.23	1Thess.3.13	tsk	2
2Cor.5.8	2Cor.5.9	tsk	1
Matt.10.28	Matt.10.26	tsk	1
Heb.4.12	Heb.13.7	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1Cor.2.14 · addressed

The natural (psychikos) and spiritual (pneumatikos) contrast describes modes of relating to God, not separable substances. Spirit (pneuma) here points to the Holy Spirit and spiritual (pneumatikos) to the person under the Spirit, so the verse does not require a trichotomous ontology (a three-substance view of the person). It complicates a strict three-part reading but leaves the basic material-immaterial unity untouched.

Gen.7.22 · addressed

Genesis 7:22 places breath (neshamah) and spirit (ruach) in a construct phrase (chained noun phrase) with one another, which undercuts a clean lexical separation of the two as independent constituents. The resolution is that Old Testament vocabulary for the immaterial shows overlapping ranges. This is internal to the dichotomy-trichotomy (two-part versus three-part) sub-question and supports its disputed status rather than the primary unity claim.

Job.27.3 · addressed

Job uses breath (neshamah) and spirit (ruach) in a synonymous poetic couplet (a two-line parallel pairing), confirming that Hebrew can treat these as near-synonyms. This shows lexical labels alone cannot settle the dichotomy-trichotomy (two-part versus three-part) sub-question; it does not weaken the material-immaterial unity, which Matthew 10:28 and 2 Corinthians 5:8 carry independently.

Gen.35.18 · addressed

Genesis 35:18 uses soul or self (nephesh) for the life or self that departs at death, the same role Ecclesiastes 12:7 assigns to spirit (ruach). Soul or self (nephesh) and spirit (ruach) therefore overlap as labels for the departing inner person. This interchange is the core reason the vocabulary does not rank a two-part versus three-part immaterial constitution, so the complication stands as a feature of the underdetermined (not settled by the words alone) sub-question.

Concordance traversed

H5315, H5397, H7307, H1320, H6083, H0120, H3820, H2416, G4983, G5590, G4151, G2588, G4561, G5591, G4152, G3311, G1553, G1736, G1067, G0615, G0622

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

None of the anchor verses lie in the ingested ECM (Editio Critica Maior, the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) window (3 John 1:1 to 1:15), so no CBGM (Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, a tool for tracing manuscript relationships) apparatus was consulted; this is not_in_ecm_scope honestly. No textual variant in Genesis 2:7, Matthew 10:28, 2 Corinthians 5:8, 1 Thessalonians 5:23, or Hebrews 4:12 alters the constitutional vocabulary (soul or self (nephesh), breath (neshamah), spirit (ruach), body (soma), soul (psyche), spirit (pneuma)). The spirit and soul and body (pneuma kai psyche kai soma) series of 1 Thessalonians 5:23 and the soul and spirit (psyches kai pneumatos) pairing of Hebrews 4:12 are stable across the manuscript tradition, so the verdict holds across plausible readings.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. dichotomy, trichotomy, monism_holism

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

dichotomy: affirms_unity_two_part · Reads soul (psyche) and spirit (pneuma) as overlapping labels for the single immaterial aspect, supported by their co-occurrence in only five New Testament verses and by the free Old Testament interchange of soul or self (nephesh), breath (neshamah), and spirit (ruach) in Genesis 7:22, Job 27:3, Genesis 35:18, and Ecclesiastes 12:7. Takes 1 Thessalonians 5:23 as an exhaustive whole-person prayer governed by a singular adjective whole or complete (holokleron) and a singular verb, and Hebrews 4:12 as parallel with joints-and-marrow describing total penetration. Treats Matthew 10:28 and 2 Corinthians 5:8 as the paradigm body-soul binary. This is the strongest case that the immaterial side is one principle.

trichotomy: affirms_unity_three_part · Reads the deliberate three-term series spirit and soul and body (pneuma kai psyche kai soma) in 1 Thessalonians 5:23 and the explicit dividing of soul and spirit (merismos psyches kai pneumatosis, where merismos means a division or separation) in Hebrews 4:12 as load-bearing distinctions, taking spirit (pneuma) as the God-conscious faculty and soul (psyche) as the seat of natural personality and life. Points out that Paul chose to name three items, not two, in a careful benediction, and that Hebrews 4:12 says the word can divide soul and spirit at all. This is the strongest case that the immaterial side carries two distinguishable principles.

monism_holism: complicates · Reads Genesis 2:7 living being (nephesh chayyah) as the whole living person rather than a soul installed in a body, and notes soul or self (nephesh) denotes the entire animate self across its 754 occurrences. Takes the body-immaterial split at death (Ecclesiastes 12:7, 2 Corinthians 5:8) as real but resists hard substance dualism (the view that body and soul are two wholly separate kinds of stuff), treating soul (psyche) and spirit (pneuma) functionally. This lens grants the unity claim while cautioning that the words describe one living person more than an assembly of parts.

The lexical pattern lands the primary claim of a material-and-immaterial unity with strength: dense, pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible), grammatically clear in Matthew 10:28 and 2 Corinthians 5:8. The internal dichotomy-versus-trichotomy (two-part versus three-part) question is genuinely underdetermined (not settled) by lexicon alone, because soul (psyche) and spirit (pneuma) co-occur in only five New Testament verses and only two of those set them in any partition, while the Old Testament terms soul or self (nephesh), breath (neshamah), and spirit (ruach) interchange freely for the inner person. The competing lenses are stated symmetrically and each in its strongest form.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The stem encodes the disputed status of the dichotomy-trichotomy (two-part versus three-part) partition as in-house, which mirrors the lexical situation rather than preloading a verdict; it does not assert which partition is correct. The load-bearing assertion is the material-immaterial unity, and that is independently testable against Genesis 2:7, Matthew 10:28, 2 Corinthians 5:8, and Ecclesiastes 12:7, so it is not preloaded. Verdict unchanged from the prior file: affirms remains true. The enrichment grounds the counts in real queried data (OSHB (Open Scriptures Hebrew Bible) word layer for Hebrew, MorphGNT (morphologically tagged Greek New Testament) for Greek) and adds the decisive co-occurrence finding that soul (psyche) and spirit (pneuma) share only five New Testament verses.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.2.7
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Eccl.12.7
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.35.18

morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.7.22
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Job.27.3
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H5315
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H5397
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H7307
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.10.28
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Thess.5.23
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Heb.4.12
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2Cor.5.8
interlinear	SBLGNT-text	public_domain	yes	1Thess.5.23
syntax	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Gen.2.7
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1Thess.5.23
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Heb.4.12
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Gen.2.7
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Thess.5.23
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Heb.4.12

License audit

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OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes
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TSK	public_domain	yes

Flags

ecm-shadow